MODULE 1

CASE STUDY

BioNTech: The Decade Before the Pandemic

How a husband-wife team in Mainz bet everything on a technology nobody believed in

Prepare this case before class. Come ready to take a position.

THE SITUATION

BioNTech, 2017

Ugur Sahin and Ozlem Tureci have spent 10+ years developing mRNA technology for cancer immunotherapy. Results have been promising but modest. The company has 1,300 employees and over €1B invested.

Sahin believes mRNA could be a platform technology for infectious diseases — not just cancer. But there's no pandemic to fight, and infectious disease is dominated by established pharma giants with decades of vaccine infrastructure.

KEY FACTS

- Founded 2008 in Mainz
- Husband-wife founders (both MDs)
- €1.3B total funding by 2017
- mRNA cancer pipeline: Phase I/II
- No infectious disease product yet
- Competing with Moderna (founded 2010)

THE DECISION

Should BioNTech redirect significant resources toward pandemic preparedness?

OPTION A

Stay focused on cancer — it's your core competency and where the clinical data is

OPTION B

Diversify into infectious disease — begin a small R&D program alongside cancer work

OPTION C

Make a big bet — pivot major resources toward mRNA pandemic platform

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Come prepared to defend your position with evidence from the case.

1. How do you evaluate 'why now' when the market (pandemic preparedness) doesn't visibly exist yet?
2. What role did Sahin and Tureci's complementary skills play in BioNTech's success?
3. How is this a lesson about conviction vs. evidence? When should founders trust their gut over data?
4. What can European entrepreneurs learn from BioNTech's decision to stay in Mainz rather than move to Boston?